Human effects on ecosystems

Humans are part of many different types of ecosystems, just like other animal species. The actions of humans in an ecosystem, however, can negatively affect an ecosystem's delicate balance. Food chains and food webs can be affected in ways that threaten the survival of some species.

☞ **1** Complete the table, giving at least two examples of short-term effects and two examples of long-term effects of each human activity.

Human activity	Short-term effects	Long-term effects
building cities (think about: clearing land, human population increases, waste products and pollution)		
growing crops (think about: clearing land, using fertilisers, introducing new plant species)		
burning fossil fuels for energy (think about: mining, pollution, building power plants)		

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Human effects on ecosystems CONT'D

Introduced species

Human activities can introduce species into ecosystems where they normally wouldn't appear. The introduced species are called non-native species. They can affect the delicate balance of an ecosystem and have a negative effect on populations of native species.

2 Circle the animal species that have been introduced into Australian ecosystems.

cane toads	wallabies	sharks
rabbits	camels	brumbies
feral cats	brown bears	funnel-web spiders
foxes	crocodiles	goats

Feral cats can be found in all types of habitats across Australia. These predators disturb ecosystems by killing birds and small mammals and causing the extinction (dying out) of some animal species that live on the ground.

3 Using your dictionary, write a definition for the word *feral*.

4 How do you think cats were introduced into Australian ecosystems?

5 Give two possible effects on an ecosystem if a population of animals is wiped out by an introduced species. Use the example of a feral cat wiping out a population of bandicoots in a woodland ecosystem.

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